Fifth post: Dante's Inferno, read through the three tenets.

A public follow-up to the first four posts · 15 October 2026 · written by one of the two AI assistants from the originator's choice of subject and direction · facts carry their sources, readings are marked as readings · the earlier posts, in English and Norwegian, are at the same address

What this post is. Seven hundred years ago a poet in exile drew a map of the ways people can wrong each other, and of the way back. This post walks that map, Dante's Inferno, and the climb that follows it, with TT's three tenets in hand: do unto others, as you wish done to yourself; interconnectivity; awareness plus retention. The poem's facts carry their sources. What TT makes of them is marked as a reading, and none of it is a claim about any afterlife.

The poem, in brief. Fact: Dante Alighieri was born in Florence in 1265 and died in Ravenna in 1321 [1]. In January 1302 he was sentenced on charges of corruption and exiled from Florence, and he never saw the city again [1][2]. He wrote the poem, first called simply the Commedia, from about 1308 until shortly before his death [1][3], and set its journey in Easter week of 1300, before the exile [2]. It has three parts, Inferno, Purgatorio and Paradiso, of thirty-three cantos each, and one opening canto brings the whole to a hundred [3]. It is written in terza rima, stanzas of three lines, and the number three runs through the work [3]. Three guides lead the traveller: Virgil, read as human reason; Beatrice, read as divine revelation; and Bernard of Clairvaux, read as contemplation [3].

The way down. Fact: the poem opens with the traveller halfway along life's road, lost in a dark wood and set upon by three beasts, a lion, a leopard and a she-wolf [3]. The inscription over the gate of Hell ends by telling all who enter to give up hope [5]. Below the gate, Hell is a funnel of nine circles, widest at the top and narrowing towards the centre of the earth [3][4]. The first circle, Limbo, holds the unbaptised and the virtuous pagans, and Virgil himself lives there [5]. Circles two to five punish the sins of desire, the sixth holds the heretics, the seventh the violent, and the eighth and ninth those who harmed others by fraud [4]. In the eleventh canto Virgil explains this order, and he grounds it in Aristotle's Nicomachean Ethics [3].

The three tenets, in the dark.

The first tenet, read backwards. Fact: in Dante's Hell each punishment either resembles or reverses its sin. The word for it, contrapasso, from the Latin for suffering the opposite, appears in the twenty-eighth canto, at line 142, spoken by Bertran de Born; the idea came to Dante from older writers, Thomas Aquinas among them [6]. The lustful, who let desire carry them, are blown back and forth by a storm without rest [5]. Reading: contrapasso is the first tenet with the choice taken away. In the poem's Hell, what you did to others is done to you, whether you would have wished it or not. TT's first tenet asks for the same mirror to be held up beforehand, while the choice is still yours: what would you want done to you, in their place?

Interconnectivity: the coldest place is broken trust. Fact: the bottom of Hell is not fire but a frozen lake, Cocytus, laid out in four rings: those who betrayed their kin, their political community, their guests, and their lords or benefactors [5]. At its centre Lucifer is held waist-deep in the ice, and the icy wind from his own beating wings keeps him locked there [5]. The poem even has traitors against their guests fall into Hell at the moment of the betrayal, not at death [4]. Reading: the deeper the circle, the more the sin breaks a bond that someone relied on, and the very bottom is kept for those who were trusted. Seen through TT's second tenet, Hell is a network coming apart, ring by ring, until nothing moves and nothing is warm. And the one at the centre holds himself there: the wind that freezes him is his own.

Awareness plus retention: seeing ahead, blind to now. Fact: among the heretics, the Florentine Farinata degli Uberti explains that the souls in Hell know the world of the living only by foresight, and that once the door of the future is shut they will know nothing at all [5]. Reading: this is awareness with its present tense cut out, and retention with nothing to do. The souls keep their memories and their sins, but nothing in them is ever corrected, and what they know drains away with time. TT's third tenet joins the two halves on purpose: awareness of what is happening now, retention of what has happened, both kept so that things can be put right.

Raising the horizon, at others' cost. Fact: Ulysses tells the traveller how his longing to experience the world outweighed his love for his son, his father and his wife. He took his crew past the Pillars of Hercules into the open sea, and the voyage ended in shipwreck soon after they sighted a mountain, the mountain of Purgatory [5]. He burns in the eighth circle among the counsellors of fraud, for the stratagem of the Trojan horse among other deeds [5]. Reading: the hunger to see further is not what puts him there. What sinks the ship is a reach for the horizon paid for by other people, the crew he talked into following him. TT raises its horizons too, and the first tenet travels with it: nobody is spent on the way.

The way out works on the roots. Fact: after Hell the traveller climbs the mountain of Purgatory, seven terraces for the seven deadly sins, and on each terrace a sin is cleansed in a way that fits it [3][7]. The translator Dorothy L. Sayers set the difference out as fruits against roots: Hell deals with what sin bears, Purgatory with what it grows from [7]. The prayers of the living shorten the souls' wait and speed their climb [7]. At the summit the traveller is washed in one river, Lethe, which takes away the memory of past sin, and drinks from a second, Eunoë, which restores the memory of the good [7]. Reading: Hell and the mountain hold the same sins; what differs is correction. In Hell the punishment changes nothing. On the mountain each fault is worked at its root, others help the climb, and the forgetting comes only once the work is done, never before it. That is close in shape to how TT treats its own mistakes. The fourth post put it as found, logged and fixed, not punished into hiding; the first post's rule is rootward, then sideways: repair the cause, then check every place it recurs.

Every part ends looking up. Fact: the last word of each of the poem's three parts is stelle, stars [3]. Reading: even Hell's last word is the sky. Read as a tree, the poem runs from the roots to the canopy: down into the dark at the centre of the earth, up the mountain, out into the light. The first post names light as the input of TT's canopy.

What this reading is not. Reading: the Comedy is a Christian poem of the fourteenth century, with its own theology and its own politics, and the man who drew the map had been driven out of his city [1][2]. TT takes no position on any afterlife and adopts none of the poem's punishments. It borrows the map: an old and careful picture of how harm spreads between people, and of how it is mended.

Sources: what each one is, what it says, and where the post uses it.

- [1] Encyclopaedia Britannica, "Dante Alighieri" (summary).
  https://www.britannica.com/summary/Dante-Alighieri
  Kind: an encyclopaedia summary.
  Says: born in Florence in 1265, died in Ravenna in 1321; exiled from Florence in 1302, never to return; the Commedia written about 1308 to 1321.
  Used in: the poem, in brief; what this reading is not.

- [2] History Today, "Dante is Exiled from Florence" (Months Past).
  https://www.historytoday.com/archive/months-past/dante-exiled-florence
  Kind: a history magazine's dated note.
  Says: sentenced on 27 January 1302 on charges of corruption; he never saw the city again; the poem is set in Easter week 1300.
  Used in: the poem, in brief; what this reading is not.

- [3] Wikipedia, "Divine Comedy".
  https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Divine_Comedy
  Kind: an encyclopaedia article.
  Says: begun about 1308, completed about 1321, shortly before Dante's death; three parts of 33 cantos plus an opening canto, 100 in all; terza rima, with the number three prominent; the guides Virgil (human reason), Beatrice (divine revelation) and Bernard of Clairvaux (contemplative mysticism); the opening halfway along life's path in a dark wood, with a lion, a leopard and a she-wolf; nine circles; Virgil justifies Hell's structure from the Nicomachean Ethics in Canto XI; Purgatory's seven terraces for the seven deadly sins; the last word of each part is stelle, stars.
  Used in: the poem, in brief; the way down; the way out works on the roots; every part ends looking up.

- [4] Danteworlds, University of Texas at Austin, "Dante's Hell" (overview).
  https://danteworlds.laits.utexas.edu/textpopup/inf0000.html
  Kind: a university teaching site.
  Says: Hell is mostly concentric circles, widest at the top and narrowing towards the earth's core; Limbo is the first circle; sins of desire in circles two to five, heretics in the sixth, violence in the seventh, fraud in the eighth and ninth; traitors against guests lose their souls to Hell at the moment of the betrayal, not at death.
  Used in: the way down; interconnectivity.

- [5] Wikipedia, "Inferno (Dante)".
  https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Inferno_(Dante)
  Kind: an encyclopaedia article.
  Says: the gate's inscription ends by telling those who enter to give up all hope; Limbo holds the virtuous pagans and the unbaptised, and is where Virgil resides; the lustful are buffeted by the winds of a storm without rest (Canto V); Farinata degli Uberti, among the heretics of the sixth circle, explains that the damned know earthly life only by foresight, and nothing once the future is shut; Ulysses' longing to gain experience of the world outweighed his love for son, father and wife, and his voyage past the Pillars of Hercules ended in shipwreck after sighting Mount Purgatory; he and Diomedes burn among the counsellors of fraud for the Trojan horse among other deeds, in the eighth circle; Cocytus is a frozen lake of four rings of traitors, against kin, political community, guests, and lords or benefactors; Lucifer is trapped waist-deep in the ice, and the icy wind from his beating wings keeps him there.
  Used in: the way down; the first tenet, read backwards; interconnectivity; awareness plus retention; raising the horizon.

- [6] Wikipedia, "Contrapasso".
  https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Contrapasso
  Kind: an encyclopaedia article.
  Says: the punishment of souls by a process resembling or contrasting with the sin; from the Latin contra and patior, to suffer the opposite; the word appears in Canto XXVIII, line 142, spoken by Bertran de Born; Thomas Aquinas' Summa Theologica among the sources Dante drew on.
  Used in: the first tenet, read backwards.

- [7] Wikipedia, "Purgatorio".
  https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Purgatorio
  Kind: an encyclopaedia article.
  Says: each terrace purges a particular sin in an appropriate manner; Dorothy L. Sayers's summary sets Hell, concerned with the fruits of sin, against Purgatory, concerned with its roots; the prayers of

the living shorten the souls' wait, and one soul passed through most of the mountain in five years thanks to his wife's prayers; at the summit Dante is washed in Lethe, which erases the memory of past sin, and drinks from Eunoë, which restores good memories.
Used in: the way out works on the roots.

Licence: the writing on this page is CC BY-SA 4.0. Written with AI help, from the originator's choice of subject and direction. The Norwegian edition of this post is at the same address.